October 15th, 2026

To: Winchester Town Meeting

RE: FY 2027 Winchester Capital Planning Report

From: Enzo Rascionato, Chair, Winchester Capital Planning Committee

CC: Winchester Select Board
Christopher Senior, Winchester Town Manager
Winchester Finance Committee
Philip Frattaroli, Winchester Town Meeting Moderator

This report contains the Capital Planning Committee's (CPC) recommendations for the FY27 capital budget, which runs from July 1, 2026 to June 30, 2027, along with our view of the Town's capital needs over the next five years (FY27–FY31).

We also include

- *Article 8 – Project Closeouts:* This article closes out completed capital projects and transfers the remaining unspent balances, totaling $26,864.54, to the appropriate Town funds
- *Article 10-15 Project Descriptions:* complete description of every recommended project for this year's Fall Town Meeting projects
- *Appendix - Background materials (process and funding sources):* how each funding source works, and additional information on CPC processes

What We Are Recommending

Our Fall Town Meeting recommendations by funding source:

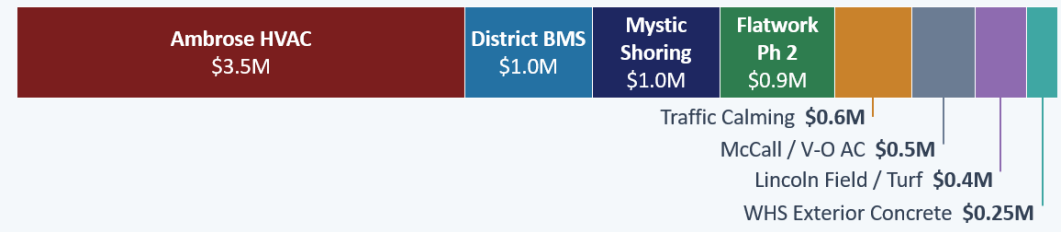
Fund	Amount	Articles	What it pays for
Building Stabilization Fund (BSF)	$1,480,000*	10, 11, 15	HVAC and controls design; building and field structural repairs; Lincoln School walkways and stairs
Capital Stabilization Fund (CSF)	$2,450,000	12, 13	Vehicles; roads, sidewalks and traffic safety
Cemetery Perpetual Care Fund (PCF)	$140,000	14	Columbarium
Water & Sewer Retained Earnings (WRE)	$700,000	14	Raw Water Pump Building repairs; Water Treatment Plant backwash basin design
Total	**$4,770,000***		

** Project closeouts and unexpended bond proceeds will fund a portion of one of these projects.*

Projects by Article are as follows:

Article	Project	Fund	Amount	Article Total
Article 10 Building HVAC & Controls	Ambrose School HVAC Repair & Replacement Design	BSF	$300,000	**$410,000**
	District-Wide BMS Upgrades Design	BSF	$60,000	
	McCall and Vinson-Owen AC Expansion Feasibility Study	BSF	$50,000	
Article 11 Building & Field Structural Repairs	High School Exterior Concrete Assessment & Design	BSF	$30,000	**$170,000**
	Lincoln School Field Landscaping/Turf Design	BSF	$40,000	
	Mystic School Shoring Design	BSF	$100,000	
Article 12 Vehicles	Fire Department E4 Engine Replacement	CSF	$1,100,000	**$1,730,000**
	DPW Transfer Station Tractor Cab	CSF	$275,000	
	DPW Highway Hot Box/Asphalt Truck Replacement	CSF	$240,000	
	DPW Facilities Utility Vehicle	CSF	$115,000	
Article 13 Streets	DPW Roads and Sidewalks	CSF	$550,000	**$720,000**
	Engineering Lines and Signs Safety Program	CSF	$100,000	
	Engineering Traffic Calming Studies	CSF	$70,000	
Article 14 Cemetery & Water/Sewer	Columbarium (Phase 1)	PCF	$140,000	**$840,000**
	Raw Water Pump Building Repairs	WRE	$600,000	
	WTP Backwash Basin Design	WRE	$100,000	
Article 15	Lincoln School Flatwork Construction – Phase 1	BSF	$900,000	**$900,000**

This year's recommended projects have several (highlighted in yellow) that are design projects that will then have expected future investment costs – spending commitments on these projects are estimated to be an *additional* $8.15M in post-FY27:



Key highlights of FY27 recommended investments include:

- **Ambrose School HVAC design ($300K, estimated construction cost ~$3.5M):** The heating water piping in the 2005 building is deteriorating, and a pipe failure would disrupt heat for the whole school. Designing will allow us to choose between repair and replacement.
- **Engine 4 replacement ($1.1M):** The current engine is from 2010, and new engines take ~2 years from order to delivery, so it will be at or near 20 years of service by the time a replacement arrives. Ordering now keeps a reliable front-line engine in service. We reserved a total of $1 million of CSF funding over the past two years in anticipation of this purchase, aware also that another fire truck purchase is in the queue for next year.
- **Lincoln School flatwork, Phase 1 ($900K, Phase 2 will also be ~$900K):** The concrete walkways and stairs on the Mystic Valley Parkway side have shifted and deteriorated, creating trip hazards and falling short of accessibility requirements. Design estimated 2 phases of $900K each ($1.8M total), so we recommend tackling the first phase. While the CPC voted to recommend funding this from the BSF, closeouts and unexpended bond proceeds from prior projects will also fund a portion of this expense, so it has been given a separate article, Article 15. This project has been on the unfunded list for several years.

- **District-wide building management system (BMS) design ($60K, implementation cost ~$1M):** This is the central control for heating, cooling and other systems across many of our buildings, and the current platform is about 20 years old, obsolete and nearing the end of manufacturer support. An assessment now gives us a plan, including IT and cybersecurity needs, before failures force emergency replacements, and it protects the HVAC work that follows.

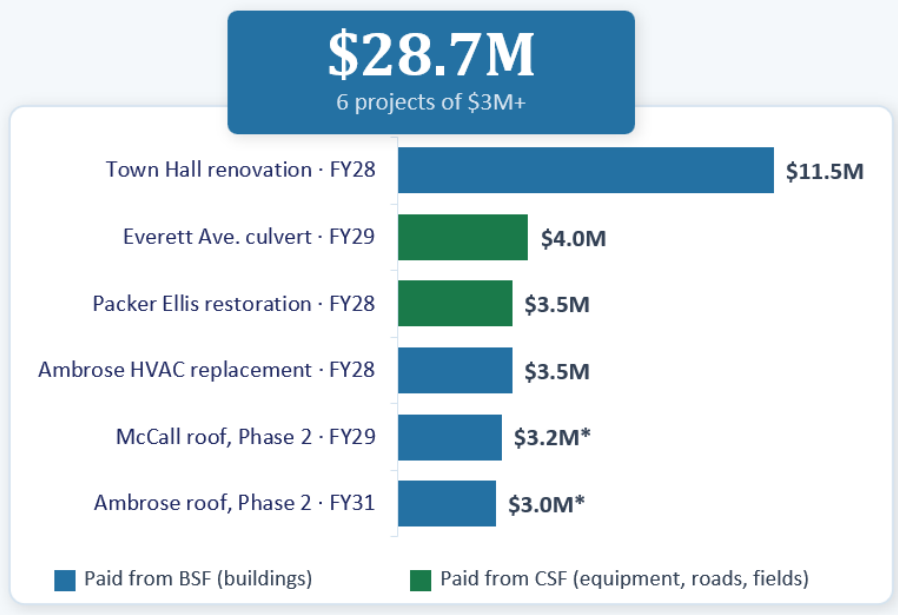
Outlook

The five-year plan (FY27–FY31) currently includes about $78.6 million in department requests. About $15.7 million of that is Water & Sewer, which is paid for through rates, retained earnings and borrowing. The other $62.9 million depends on the BSF, the CSF and, for eligible projects, Community Preservation Act (CPA) funds. We estimate those sources, together with the balances we start with, can support about $41.7 million over the five years, which leaves a gap of about $21.3 million.



** Assumes 60% of annual Community Preservation Act (CPA) funds go toward stabilization fund projects*

That gap is harder to close than the number suggests, mainly due to borrowing constraints within the two stabilization funds.



**Eligible for MSBA Accelerated Repair Program to be pursued by the School Department*

About $29M of the $62.9M comes from six very large projects (shown above) that will almost certainly require borrowing to get them done within the stabilization funds. While borrowing in BSF / CSF helps us tackle large projects, it can severely impact our ability to fund future projects. As recently as 2019, our stabilization funds were over 70% encumbered. Moving forward, we must try to keep debt service below 40% of a fund's annual capacity so there is still room for future anticipated and unanticipated needs.

Town Hall is the largest single item in the five-year plan. For last year's override discussions, Town Hall was estimated at between $13.4 - $19.4M; for the plan low end estimates are currently at ~$11.5 million. Town Meeting approved a design assessment at our last Spring Town Meeting; these results are expected in early 2027 and will drive more detailed cost and scope decisions. As in past years, we believe Town Hall should be planned and funded as a single, bundled project, which limits disruption to staff (who will need to be relocated) and the overall cost. We have done extensive modeling in our plan to determine how this could be funded; given the expected size we will almost certainly need additional funding sources beyond the stabilization funds and the CPA.

We also continued to partner closely with the Winchester Committee on Community Preservation (WCCP) to look for projects, where possible, that CPA funds can take on work that would otherwise draw on the stabilization funds. This year, for example, the WCCP is recommending funding three projects in the capital queue including design work for the Packer Ellis Tennis Courts, thereby allowing stabilization funds to go toward other necessary projects.

Acknowledgments

The CPC thanks the department heads and the Town Manager's office, in particular Town Manager Christopher Senior and Deputy Town Manager Anthony Ansaldi, for their work preparing the FY27 capital plan. We also thank Town Comptroller Stacie Ward for the financial information and support she provides to us throughout the year.

Respectfully submitted,

Enzo Rascionato, Chair, Capital Planning Committee, Select Board Appointee
Brian Vernaglia, Vice Chair, Planning Board Representative
Richard Caplow, Member, Finance Committee Representative
Olga Lane, Member, Select Board Appointee
Stefanie Mnayarji, Member, School Committee Representative
Jason Roeder, Member, Select Board Appointee
Richard Rohan, Member, Finance Committee Representative

5 Year Plan Summary

Capital Improvement Plan Five-Year Request Summary Table

Department	FY27	FY28–31	5-Year Total
Council on Aging	$250,000	$135,000	$385,000
DPW-Water/Sewer Enterprise	$700,000	$9,895,000	$10,595,000
DPW-Roads and Sidewalks	$550,000	$2,300,000	$2,850,000
DPW-Maintenance	$630,000	$1,330,000	$1,960,000
DPW-Facilities - School Building	$1,880,000	$15,606,700	$17,486,700
DPW-Facilities - Non-School Buildings	$175,000	$15,240,000	$15,415,000
Engineering - Bridges	$0	$4,400,000	$4,400,000
Engineering - MS4	$200,000	$4,900,000	$5,100,000
Engineering - Transportation	$280,000	$2,400,000	$2,680,000
Engineering - Water Quality	$75,000	$800,000	$875,000
Fire Department	$1,145,000	$2,596,862	$3,741,862
Human Resources - ADA	$125,000	$500,000	$625,000
Police Department	$0	$365,000	$365,000
Recreation	$735,000	$11,425,000	$12,160,000
Totals	**$6,745,000**	**$71,893,562**	**$78,638,562**

FY28–31totals are estimated amounts.

Department Capital Project Requests Summary

Departments have identified approximately $78.6 million in capital needs over the five-year planning period covering FY27 through FY31. Of this amount, approximately $6.75 million is requested for FY27, with an additional $71.9 million identified for FY28 through FY31.

Overall, the requests demonstrate that the Town’s most significant longer-term capital pressures are associated with maintaining and improving its building inventory, recreational infrastructure, stormwater systems, roadway & pedestrian infrastructure, and major public safety and public works assets. The substantial increase from $6.75 million in FY27 to $71.9 million in identified needs over FY28–FY31 also underscores the importance of prioritizing projects and developing a sustainable financing strategy as part of the five-year capital planning process.

FY27 Project Descriptions (by Article)

Article 8 – Prior Project Closeouts

As part of the Town's annual Capital Planning Process, the Capital Planning Committee requests updates on the status of previously approved capital projects to identify those that have been completed and can be formally closed out. Article 8 seeks to close out completed capital projects and transfer the remaining unspent balances to their appropriate funding sources. Specifically, Article 8 proposes transferring $18,277.30 to the Capital Stabilization Fund and $8,587.24 to the Cemetery Perpetual Care Fund, for a total of $26,864.54. These funds represent surplus balances from capital projects authorized at prior Town Meetings that are no longer needed for their original purposes. This action supports the Town's ongoing efforts to maintain accurate financial records, close out completed projects, and make remaining funds available for future eligible uses.

Article 10 – Building HVAC and Controls

Ambrose School HVAC Repair and Replacement Design ($300,000)

This appropriation will fund the investigation and design of improvements to the heating system at the Ambrose Elementary School, which opened in 2005. The existing heating water piping has experienced continued deterioration, creating an increasing risk of pipe failures and disruption to the building's heating system. The project will evaluate repair and replacement alternatives and develop a recommended approach based on reliability, energy efficiency, carbon reduction, construction impacts on school operations, and potential grant opportunities. Funding will also support preparation of construction documents and a final construction cost estimate for the recommended improvements.

District Wide BMS Upgrades Design ($60,000)

This appropriation will fund an assessment and design plan for upgrades to the Town's Building Management System (BMS), which provides centralized control and monitoring of HVAC and other building systems. The Town standardized its BMS platform approximately 20 years ago, and portions of the existing hardware and technology are now obsolete or approaching the end of manufacturer support. A consultant will evaluate existing systems, required IT infrastructure and cybersecurity needs, integration of older building systems, and requirements for future building projects. The resulting plan will identify recommended upgrades, establish a strategy for implementation, and provide cost estimates for future capital investment.

McCall and Vinson/Owen AC Expansion Feasibility Study ($50,000)

This appropriation will fund a feasibility study, schematic design, and cost estimates for HVAC improvements at the McCall Middle School and Vinson-Owen Elementary School. The study will evaluate existing equipment at Vinson-Owen serving the administrative core and select classrooms that is approaching the end of its useful life. It will also evaluate options for expanding air conditioning to upper-level classrooms at both Vinson-Owen and McCall. The study will identify potential improvements and associated costs to support future capital planning and improve indoor comfort and learning conditions for students and staff.

Article 11 – Building and Field Structural Repairs

High School Exterior Concrete Assessment and Design ($30,000)

This appropriation will provide funding for a professional assessment of exterior concrete conditions at Winchester High School and the design of recommended repairs. The work will evaluate the condition of

existing concrete elements, identify areas of deterioration or other deficiencies, and determine the appropriate corrective measures. Funding will also support development of plans and specifications for future repairs, allowing the Town to establish a defined scope and cost estimate before proceeding with construction.

Lincoln School Field Landscaping/Turf Design ($40,000)

This appropriation will fund the design and cost estimation for improvements to the Lincoln School play area and field, including required site drainage, artificial turf, and rubberized surfacing. The existing grass field experiences heavy daily use and has not been able to maintain a sustainable grass surface despite repeated resodding, while portions of the existing hardscape play area have reached the end of their useful life. The design will evaluate and develop improvements intended to provide more durable and reliable outdoor play surfaces and address associated drainage needs. The completed design and cost estimate will support a future construction funding request.

Mystic School Shoring Design ($100,000)

This appropriation will fund the design and cost estimation for permanent repairs to failed structural concrete piers at the Mystic School. The affected areas are currently supported by temporary shoring that requires ongoing monitoring until permanent repairs can be completed. The design will evaluate the existing conditions, develop the appropriate structural repair solution, and provide construction documents and cost estimates for the future repair project. Advancing the design will allow the Town to move toward a permanent solution and reduce the risk of further deterioration and additional temporary stabilization costs.

Article 12 – Vehicles

DPW Transfer Station Tractor Cab ($275,000)

This appropriation will fund the replacement of the DPW Transfer Station's 2004 International fifth-wheel tractor cab, which currently has approximately 454,861 miles. The Town's replacement schedule calls for this vehicle to be replaced after 20 years of service; however, replacement has been deferred for the past two years. The tractor cab is used to haul solid waste trailers from the Transfer Station to the Town's designated disposal facility. Replacement of this heavily used, aging vehicle will help ensure reliable transfer operations while reducing the risk of service disruptions and increasing maintenance costs.

DPW Facilities Utility Vehicle ($115,000)

This appropriation will provide $115,000 for the purchase of a utility vehicle for the DPW Facilities Division. The vehicle will support the Division's maintenance and repair responsibilities at Town-owned buildings and facilities, including the transportation of personnel, tools, equipment, and materials to work locations throughout the Town. The vehicle will provide Facilities staff with the equipment necessary to efficiently respond to routine maintenance needs, facility repairs, and other building-related work.

DPW Highway Hot Box/Asphalt Truck Replacement ($240,000)

This appropriation will fund the replacement of the DPW Highway Division's existing Hot Box/Asphalt Truck. This specialized vehicle is used for roadway maintenance and repair operations, including transporting and maintaining hot asphalt at the proper temperature for pothole repairs, pavement patching, and other roadway work. Replacement of the existing vehicle will provide reliable equipment for year-round roadway maintenance, improve the efficiency and quality of asphalt repairs, and reduce maintenance costs and downtime associated with aging equipment.

Fire Department E4 Engine Replacement ($1,100,000)

This appropriation will fund the replacement of the Fire Department's 2010 Pierce Engine 4. Fire apparatus currently has an estimated lead time of approximately two years from the date of order to delivery. As a result, Engine 4 will be approaching, if not at, 20 years of service by the time the replacement apparatus is placed into service. Funding the replacement in FY27 will allow the Town to begin the procurement process in advance of the existing engine reaching the end of its planned service life and help ensure the continued availability of reliable frontline fire apparatus.

Article 13 – Streets

DPW Roads and Sidewalks ($550,000)

This appropriation will provide $550,000 for the ongoing rehabilitation and improvement of the Town's roadway and sidewalk infrastructure. Funding will be used for pavement and sidewalk improvements based on condition, identified needs, and established priorities. This annual investment is intended to address deteriorating infrastructure, improve roadway and pedestrian conditions, extend the useful life of existing assets, and reduce the need for more costly reconstruction in the future.

Engineering Lines and Signs Safety Program ($100,000)

This appropriation will fund lower-cost traffic safety improvements on Forest Street, Ridge Street from Johnson Road to the Arlington line, and Grove Street from Bacon Street to the Medford line. These corridors were identified based on the Town-wide Transportation Plan, recent speed data, and crash history. Improvements will focus on speed reduction and safety measures such as specialized pavement markings, optical speed bars, speed feedback signs, advisory speed signage, and rectangular rapid flashing beacons. The program is intended to improve safety without the more extensive design and construction required for physical roadway modifications.

Engineering Traffic Calming Studies ($70,000)

This appropriation will provide funding for engineering studies to evaluate traffic calming needs and potential safety improvements at locations throughout the Town. Studies may include the collection and analysis of traffic volume, speed, and crash data, as well as evaluation of potential measures to address identified concerns. Funding will allow the Town to develop appropriate traffic calming recommendations and preliminary designs before advancing projects for future implementation.

Article 14 – Cemetery and Water/Sewer Projects

Columbarium ($140,000)

This appropriation will provide funding for the first phase of construction of a new columbarium site at the Town cemetery, following previously approved funding for project design. The Town's existing columbarium was initially developed as a pilot to evaluate demand for this alternative to traditional burial and has been successful, with approximately 95% of the available units sold. Expanding columbarium capacity will provide additional burial options while making more efficient use of the Town's limited cemetery land.

Raw Water Pump Building Repairs ($600,000)

This appropriation will fund repairs and improvements to the Raw Water Pump Building, which houses the pumps that convey reservoir water to the Town's water treatment system. While the pumping equipment was upgraded in connection with construction of the Water Treatment Plant in 1996, the building itself requires improvements to protect the facility and its equipment. Proposed work includes repairs to the roof, façade and brick walls, as well as replacement or repair of doors and other building

envelope components. Electrical and electronic components may also require upgrades as conditions are identified during construction.

WTP Backwash Basin Design ($100,000)

This appropriation will provide funding for engineering and design services associated with improvements to the Water Treatment Plant's backwash basin. The basin supports the water treatment process by receiving water generated during the backwashing and cleaning of filtration equipment. Funding will be used to evaluate existing conditions, identify necessary improvements, and develop plans and specifications for a future construction project. Completing the design phase will allow the Town to better define the scope and estimated cost of the required improvements.

Article 15 – Lincoln School Flatwork

Lincoln School Flatwork Construction – Phase 1 ($900,000)

This appropriation will fund the first phase of construction to repair and replace deteriorated concrete walkways and stairways at the Lincoln School along the Mystic Valley Parkway side of the building. The existing concrete has shifted and deteriorated, creating trip hazards and areas that no longer meet accessibility requirements. Design work for these improvements has already been completed. This phase will address identified safety and accessibility deficiencies and improve pedestrian access around the school.

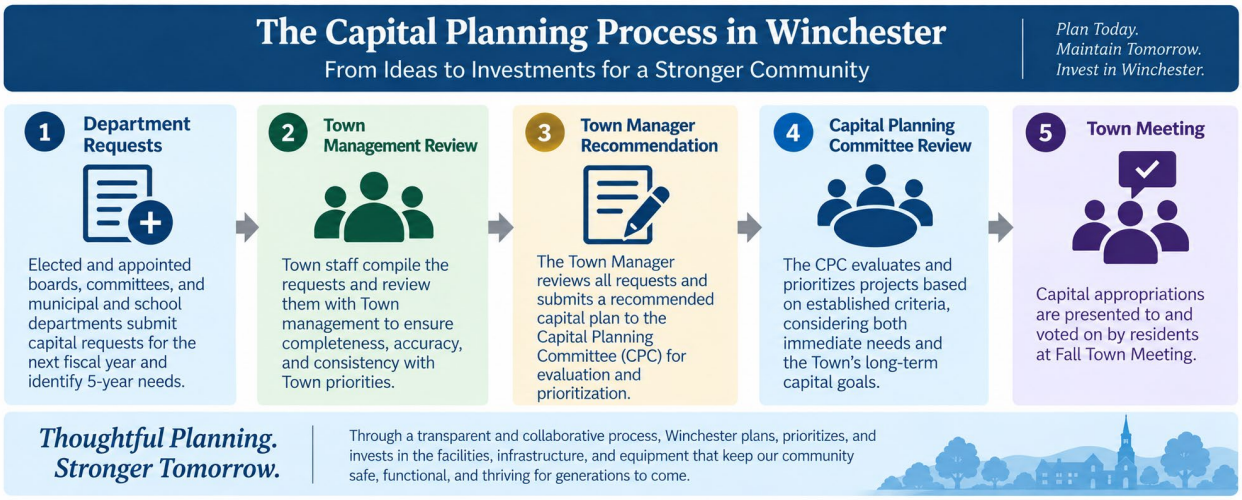
FY27 OTHER Projects

There were a number of submitted projects that were ranked below the fundable line, especially request for funds from the CST. These projects and their recommendation are outlined in the table below.

Department	Project	Amount	Recommendation
Council on Aging	Bus replacement	$250,000	*Deferred to outer year*
Engineering - Transportation	Ridge at Lockland design	$110,000	*Deferred to outer year*
Engineering - Water Quality	Winter Pond Water Quality	$75,000	*Deferred to outer year*
Fire Department	Deputy Vehicle	$45,000	*Deferred to outer year*
DPW	Building annexes restoration evaluation	$25,000	*Deferred to outer year*
Mystic	Sash Window Replacement Design	$50,000	*Deferred to outer year*
Carriage House	Abatement & Demolition	$300,000	*Deferred to outer year*
Parkhurst	Heat Pump Replacements	$200,000	*Deferred to outer year*
High School	Interior Concrete Floor Work	$1,200,000	*Deferred to outer year*
Total deferred to outer year		**$2,255,000**	
Recreation	Packer Ellis Restoration	$400,000	*Funded by WCCP*
Recreation	Leonard bathhouse demo & pavilion build	$300,000	*Funded by WCCP*
Recreation	McDonald Tennis resurfacing/improvements	$35,000	*Funded by WCCP*
Total recommended projects funded by WCCP		**$735,000**	
Engineering - MS4	MS4 Compliance	$200,000	*Fund at 2027 Spring Town Meeting*
Human Resources - ADA	ADA transition improvements to Town Hall	$125,000	*Fund at 2027 Spring Town Meeting*
Total recommended funding at 2027 Spring Town Meeting		**$325,000**	

Appendix – Background Materials

Capital Planning Process



The Town's annual capital planning process begins each June and culminates with consideration of capital appropriations at Fall Town Meeting. Elected and appointed boards and committees, as well as municipal and school departments, are asked to submit capital requests for the upcoming fiscal year and identify anticipated needs over the following five years. These submissions form the basis of the Town's comprehensive five-year capital plan.

Under the Town Charter, the CPC consists of seven appointed members:

- Two by the Finance Committee
- One by the Planning Board
- One by the School Committee
- Three by the Select Board

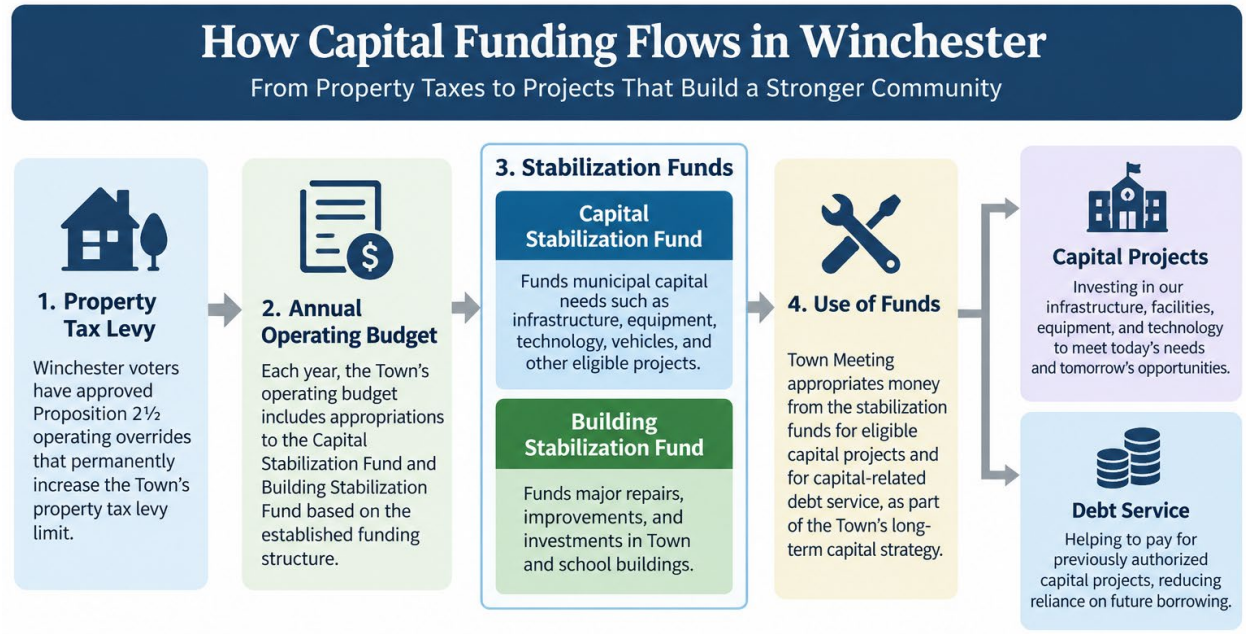
In evaluating requests, the CPC considers both immediate needs and the Town's longer-term capital requirements. Departments are expected to consider the useful life of existing assets, anticipated replacement schedules, infrastructure conditions, and future service needs when developing their requests.

While the Town Manager is ultimately responsible for developing the Town's capital plan, CPC provides an important public review of proposed investments. Its membership and public deliberations incorporate perspectives from the Select Board, Finance Committee, Planning Board, and School Committee into the capital planning process.

A consistent evaluation process is fundamental to capital planning. The CPC reviews and prioritizes projects using criteria designed to identify the Town's most important capital needs. Projects are evaluated based on:

- Public health and safety;
- State or federal mandates;
- Preservation and maintenance of Town assets; and
- Demonstrated improvements in efficiency and/or cost savings.

Funding the Capital and Building Stabilization Funds



How the Town Funds Capital Investments

As illustrated in the above chart, the Town uses a combination of recurring annual appropriations, dedicated capital reserves, and other available funding sources to support its capital program. This structure provides a predictable framework for funding ongoing capital needs while allowing resources to be accumulated for larger future projects. It also provides the Town with flexibility to determine the most appropriate funding strategy for each project, including the use of available cash resources, borrowing, or a combination of funding sources.

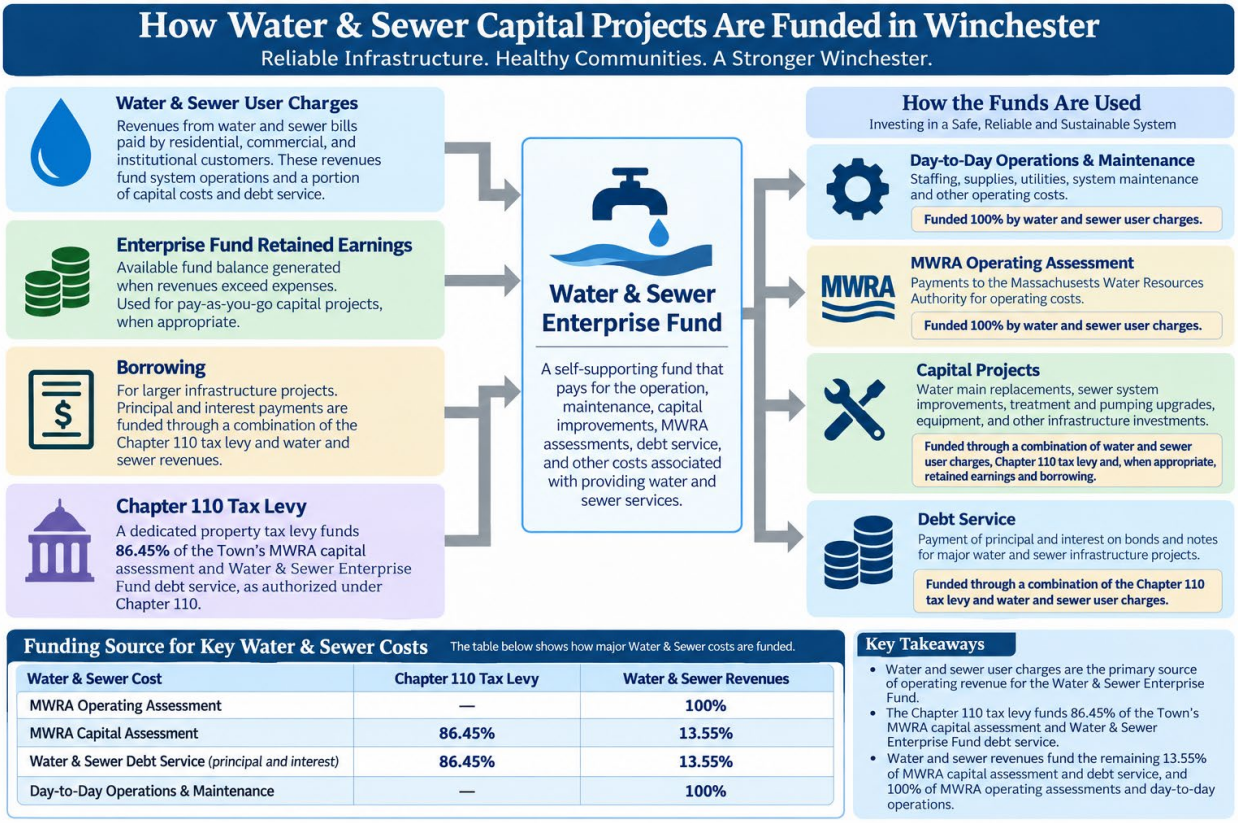
The Town of Winchester uses two stabilization funds as important sources of funding for its long-term capital needs: the Capital Stabilization Fund and the Building Stabilization Fund.

- The Capital Stabilization Fund (CSF) is used primarily to support general municipal capital needs, including equipment, infrastructure, technology, vehicles, and other eligible capital projects.
- The Building Stabilization Fund (BSF) is intended primarily for major repairs, improvements, and investments in town and school buildings.

A primary source of funding for the Town's capital program is revenue generated through Proposition 2½ operating overrides previously approved by Winchester voters. Unlike a debt exclusion, which is temporary and generally tied to a specific project, an operating override permanently increases the Town's property tax levy limit. Winchester voters have approved a dedicated override that funds the stabilization funds.

Each year, the Town's operating budget includes appropriations to the Capital Stabilization Fund and Building Stabilization Fund. These appropriations increase by 2.5% annually, consistent with Proposition 2½.

Funding Water and Sewer Capital Projects



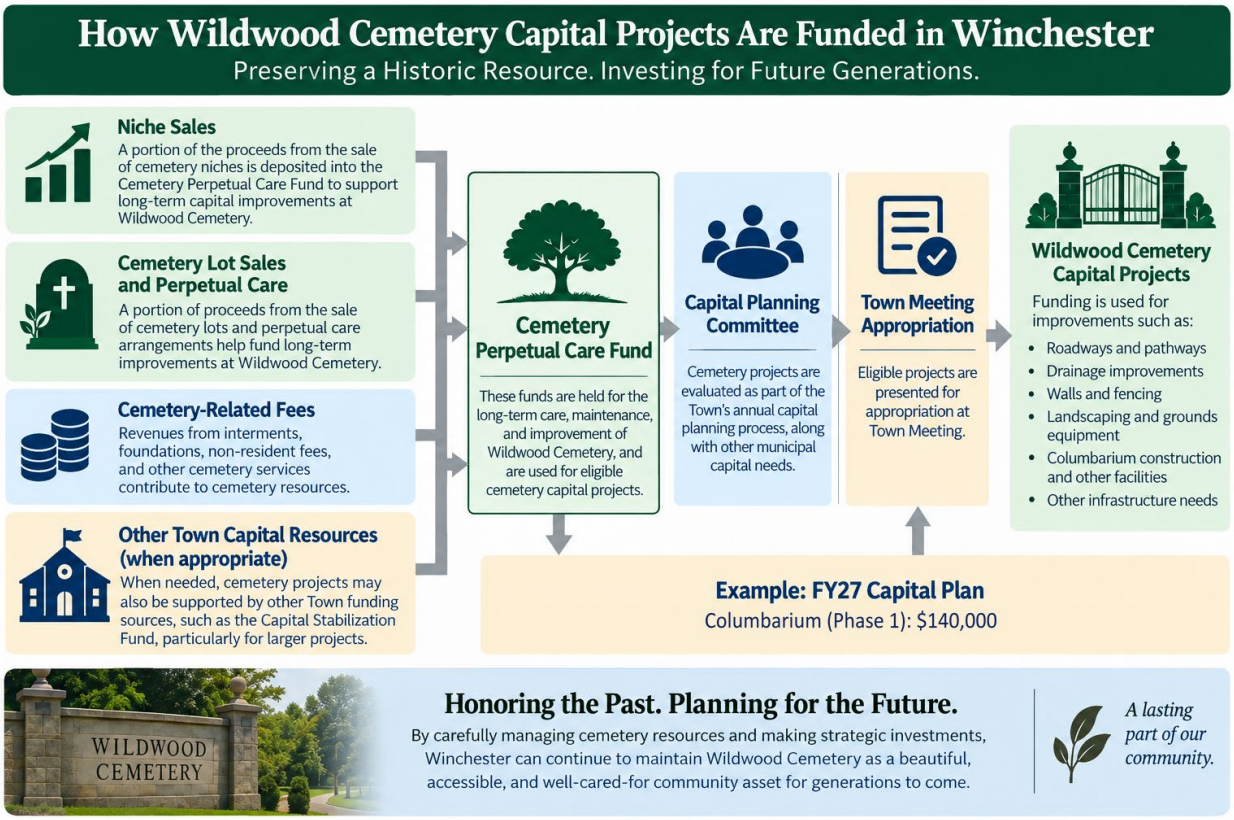
Winchester's water and sewer system is accounted for separately from the Town's General Fund through the Water & Sewer Enterprise Fund. The Enterprise Fund was established in 2002 and is designed so that the costs of operating, maintaining, and investing in the water and sewer system are primarily supported by revenues associated with providing those services.

Water and sewer user charges paid by customers are the primary source of operating revenue for the Water & Sewer Enterprise Fund and support the day-to-day operation of the Town's water and sewer systems.

Winchester has a unique funding structure for MWRA-related capital costs and Water & Sewer Enterprise Fund debt service. Under the Town's existing financing structure, 86.45% of MWRA capital assessments and Water & Sewer Enterprise Fund debt service is funded through a dedicated property tax levy, with the remaining 13.55% funded through water and sewer user charges. This differs from MWRA operating assessments, which are funded entirely through water and sewer user charges.

As part of the annual budget and capital planning process, the Town evaluates projected water and sewer revenues, operating costs, MWRA assessments, existing debt obligations, available retained earnings, and future infrastructure needs. This information is used to determine how individual capital projects should be financed and what levels of water and sewer rates are necessary to maintain the long-term financial health of the system.

Funding Cemetery Capital Projects



Wildwood Cemetery is Winchester's municipal cemetery and is maintained by the Department of Public Works. Established shortly after Winchester's incorporation, it has grown over time and today encompasses approximately 75 acres. It requires ongoing capital investment in its roads, drainage, walls, landscaping, equipment, and facilities such as columbaria.

Unlike the Town's general capital program, which relies heavily on the Capital and Building Stabilization Funds, Winchester has a dedicated funding source available for certain cemetery improvements: the Cemetery Perpetual Care Fund.

The fund is supported by money associated with cemetery lots and perpetual care arrangements, which is held for the long-term care and improvement of Wildwood Cemetery. The Town also receives cemetery-related revenues from the sale of cemetery lots, interments, foundations, non-resident fees, and other services, which are accounted for as part of the Town's financial operations.